



FOG

English - Class 10 | Complete Comprehensive Study Notes

Author: Carl Sandburg

About the Author:

Carl Sandburg was an American poet, journalist, and writer known for clear, simple language and strong imagery drawn from everyday life and nature. In Fog, he uses just a few lines to turn a natural phenomenon into a quiet, almost animal-like presence, making the poem very easy to remember but rich in meaning.

1. Themes and Values

Theme:

- The quiet, mysterious nature of fog as it moves through the city and harbour.
- Nature's gentle, stealthy presence in human life, arriving and leaving without making a loud show.
- The beauty of small, unnoticed moments in the natural world.

Values:

- Learning to notice and appreciate small, simple things in nature.

- Understanding that powerful or impressive things do not always make noise.
- Developing observation skills and a calm, thoughtful attitude towards the world.
- Valuing quiet, peaceful moments instead of only chasing loud excitement.

2. Summary

Fog is a very short poem that describes how fog arrives over a harbour and city, behaves for a while, and then disappears.

The poet imagines the fog as if it were a small cat creeping silently into the scene. It arrives quietly, covers the harbour and the city gently, sits for a while as if watching, and then quietly moves on.

The poem suggests that natural events can be beautiful and meaningful even when they are brief and soft-spoken.

Just like a cat, the fog does not announce itself with noise or drama; it slips in unnoticed, spends some time, and then leaves again, leaving behind a calm, hazy atmosphere.

By comparing the fog to a cat, the poet teaches us to see nature in familiar, friendly images, instead of only as something strange or scientific.

3. Stanza-wise Explanation

The poem has only one stanza, but it can be broken into three clear parts.

Lines 1-2:

*The fog comes
on little cat feet.*

→ Here the poet says that the fog arrives quietly, like a small cat walking on its soft paws. There is no sound, no warning - the fog just appears, almost like a stealthy visitor. The image of little cat feet makes fog feel gentle, alive, and watchful, not scary or threatening.

Lines 3-5:

*It sits looking
over harbour and city
on silent haunches.*

→ Now the fog seems to pause and look around, like a cat sitting on its haunches. It spreads over the harbour and the city, covering both the water and the buildings with a soft, grey blanket. The silent haunches again stress that this movement is quiet and smooth, not loud or violent.

Line 6:

and then moves on.

→ At the end, the fog simply leaves, just as quietly as it came. It does not stay too long; it travels on, showing that this natural event is temporary and ever-changing. This line reminds us that nature is always in motion, and even small things like fog are part of a larger, flowing world.

4. Key Literary Devices

- Metaphor: Fog is compared to a cat, which is not directly stated but strongly suggested.
- Imagery: The clear picture of fog moving over harbour and city on silent haunches creates a soft visual scene.
- Personification: The fog sits looking, as if it has a mind and can watch the world.
- Simile (implied): On little cat feet suggests a cat-like softness and silence, even though like is not used.

5. Moral

- Things that are quiet and gentle can still be powerful or beautiful.
- We should notice small, natural events like fog, rain, or wind instead of taking them for granted.
- Nature often comes and goes without any show, reminding us of the value of simplicity.
- Just like fog, people can have a calm, thoughtful presence that makes a deep but soft impact.

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